How **Social Capital** Influenced **Women's Literary Recognition** in Ancient China

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Research Topic

How social networks, especially male-female connections, influenced women’s literary status and their opportunities for having individual collections (Bieji/别集) published in ancient China.

This topic is focusing on:

- How social capital shaped women’s access to literary resources and recognition
- The role of male gatekeepers in determining women’s literary visibility

Data Introduction

China Biographical Database

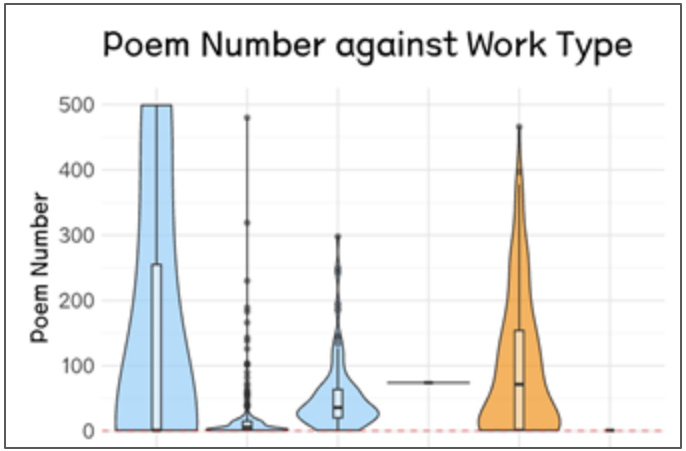
Ming Qing Women’s Writings

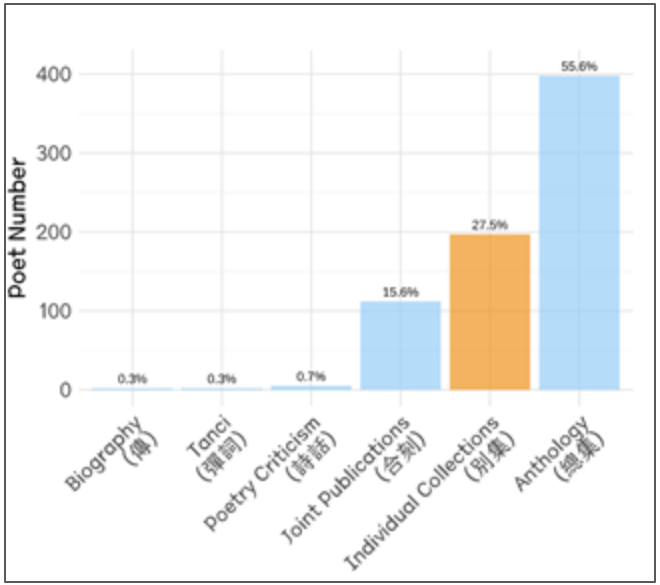
Women Poets' Literary Recognition

For Women Poets

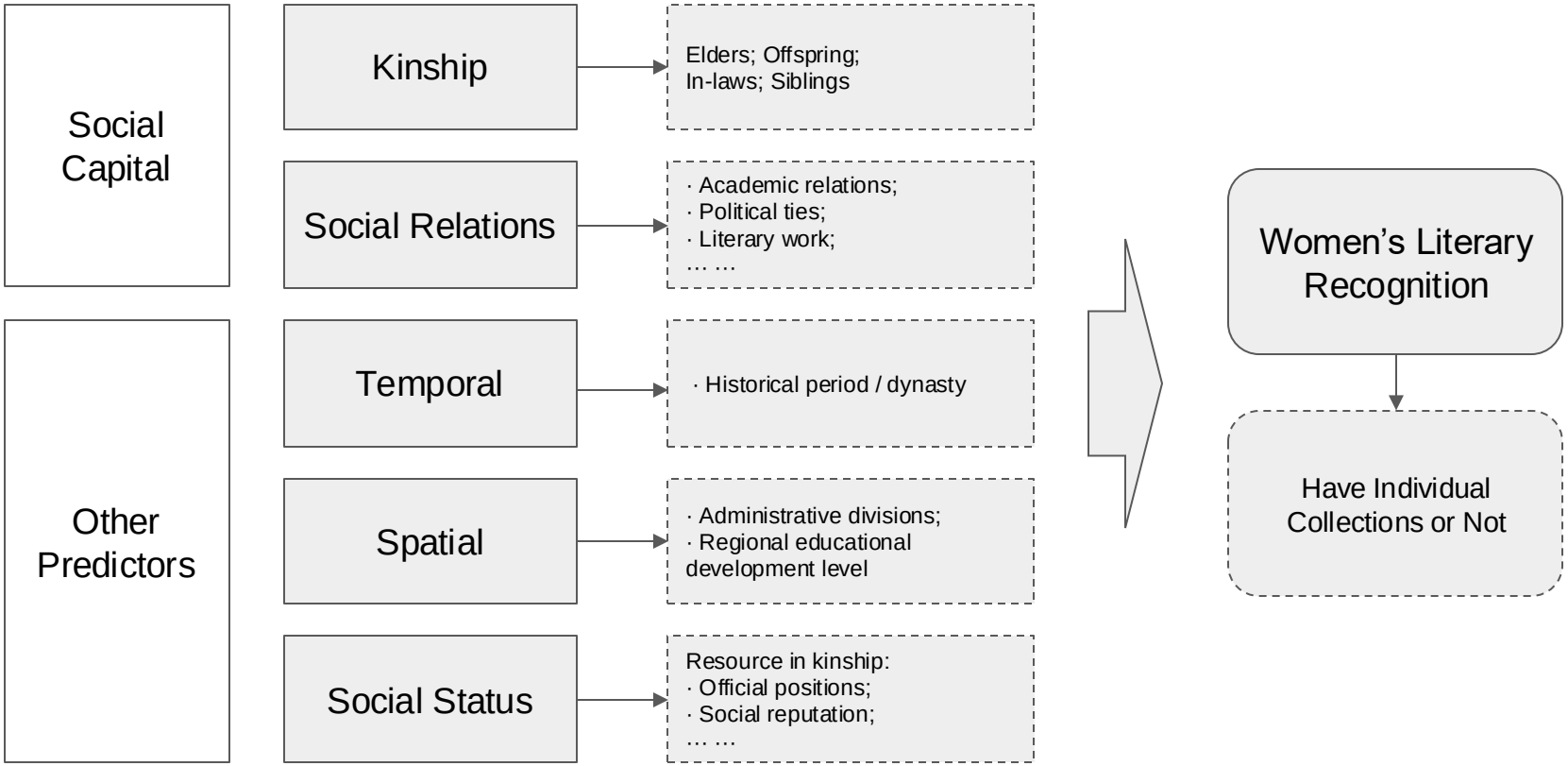
- Biography (Zhuan/傳記)
- **Individual Collections (Bieji/別集)**
- Joint Publication (Heke/合刻)
- Tanci (彈詞)
- Anthology (Zongji/總集)
- Poetry Criticism (Shihua/詩話)

$$Y = I\ (\text{Bieji} > 0)$$

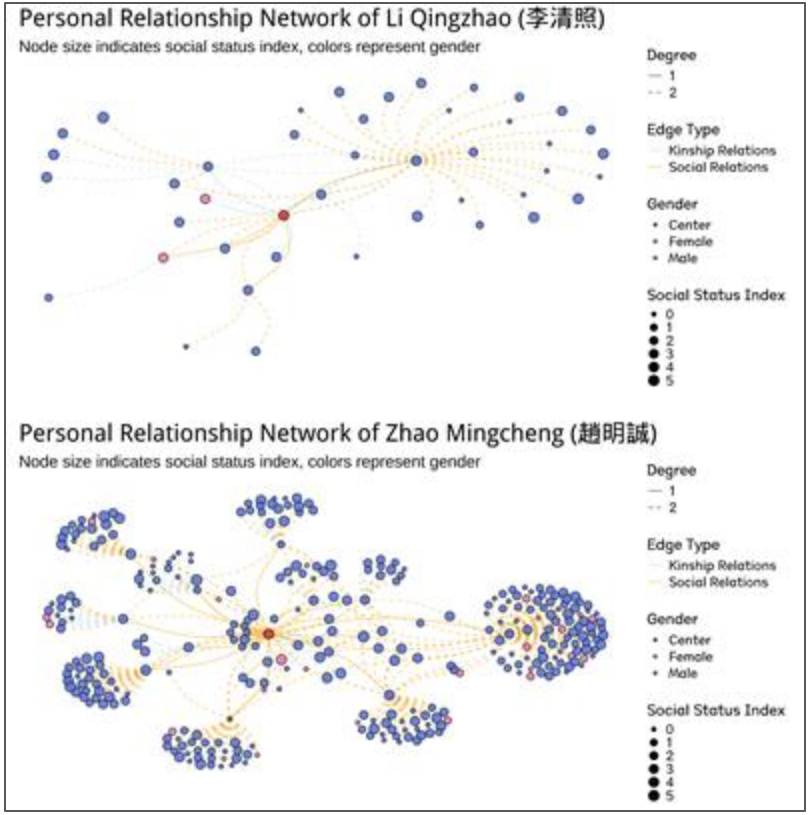




Analysis Structure



Women’s limited social capital in ancient China



Li Qingzhao had very limited social networks compared to her husband, Zhao Mingcheng, even though she is much more famous today.

Social Capital Measurement

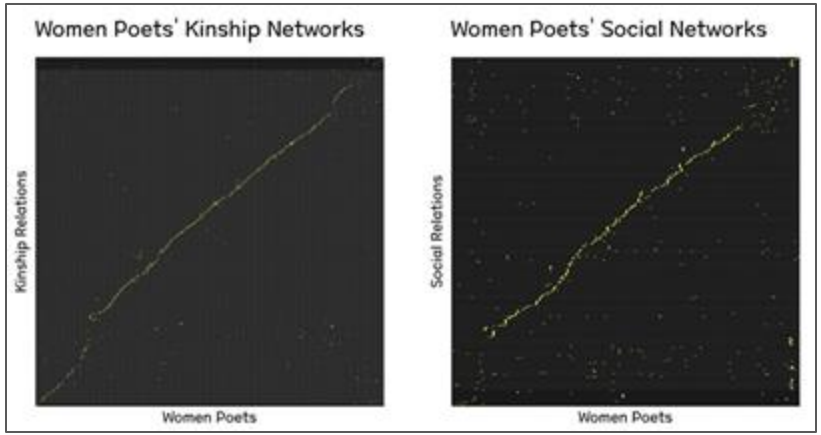
Kinship

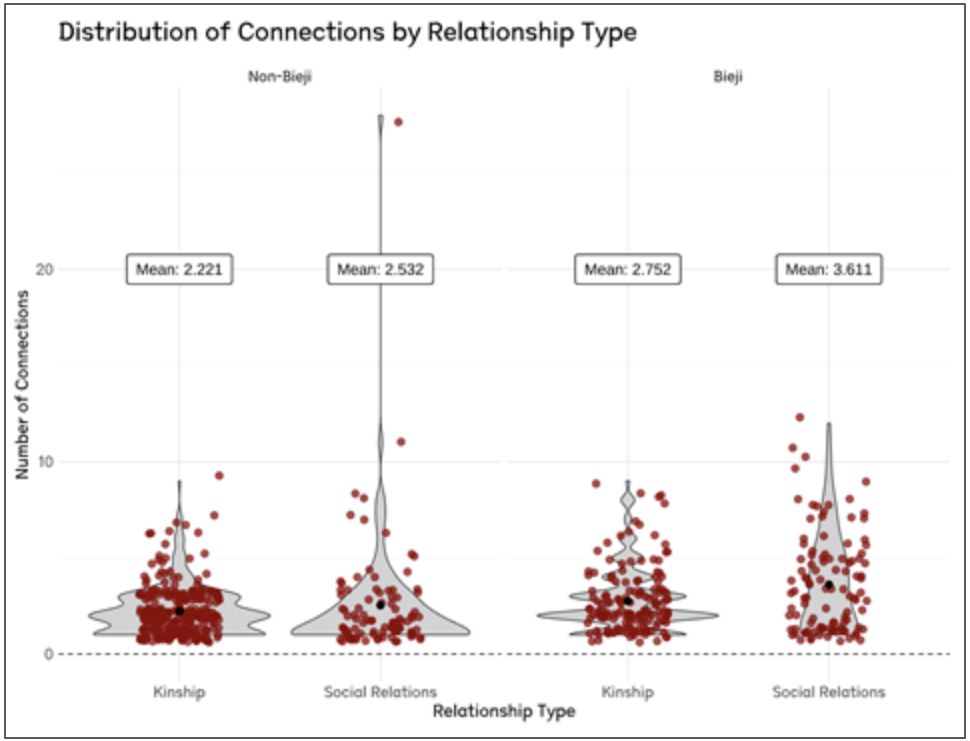
- Elders
- Offspring
- In-laws
- Siblings
- (Immediate Relatives)

Social Relations

- Academic Relations
- Political Ties
- Social Network
- Literary Work
- Artistic Exchange
- … … (10 types)

Social Capital





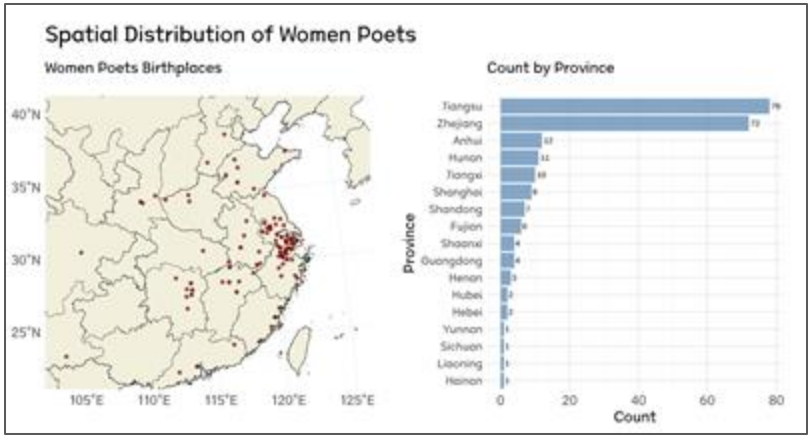
The connections in social relations are significantly richer than those in kinship.

Women who have individual collections have higher mean connection values.

Location factors

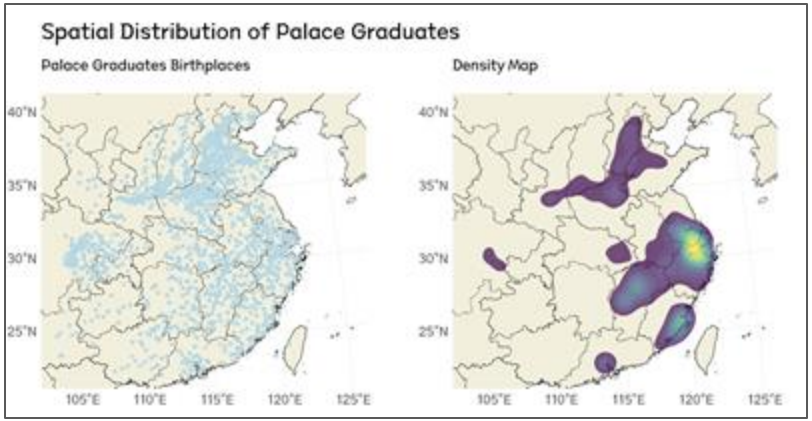
Administrative Provinces:

the different structural mechanisms within those regions.



Local Education Level:

approached by the number of Jinshi in that region.



Period factor: dynasty

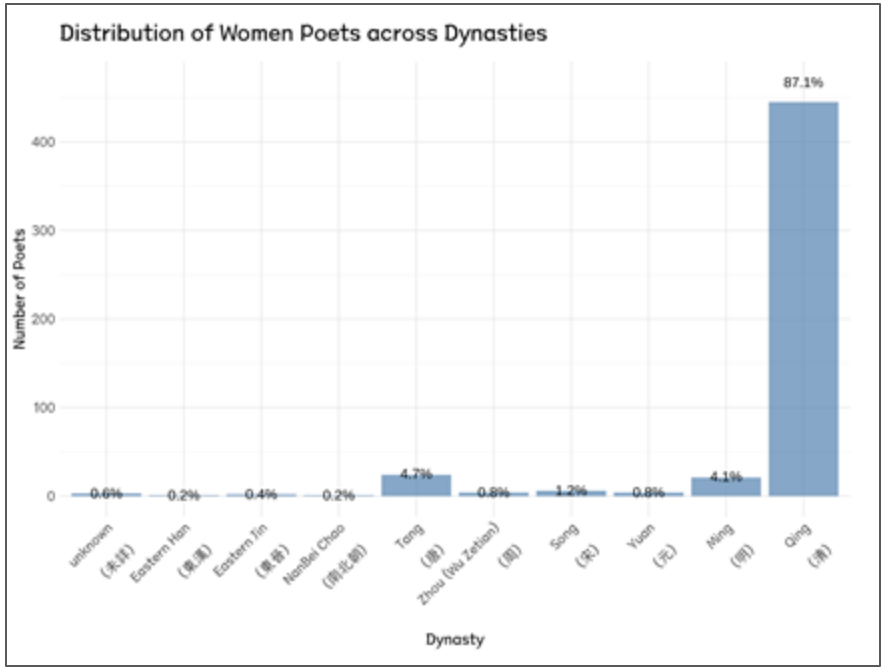
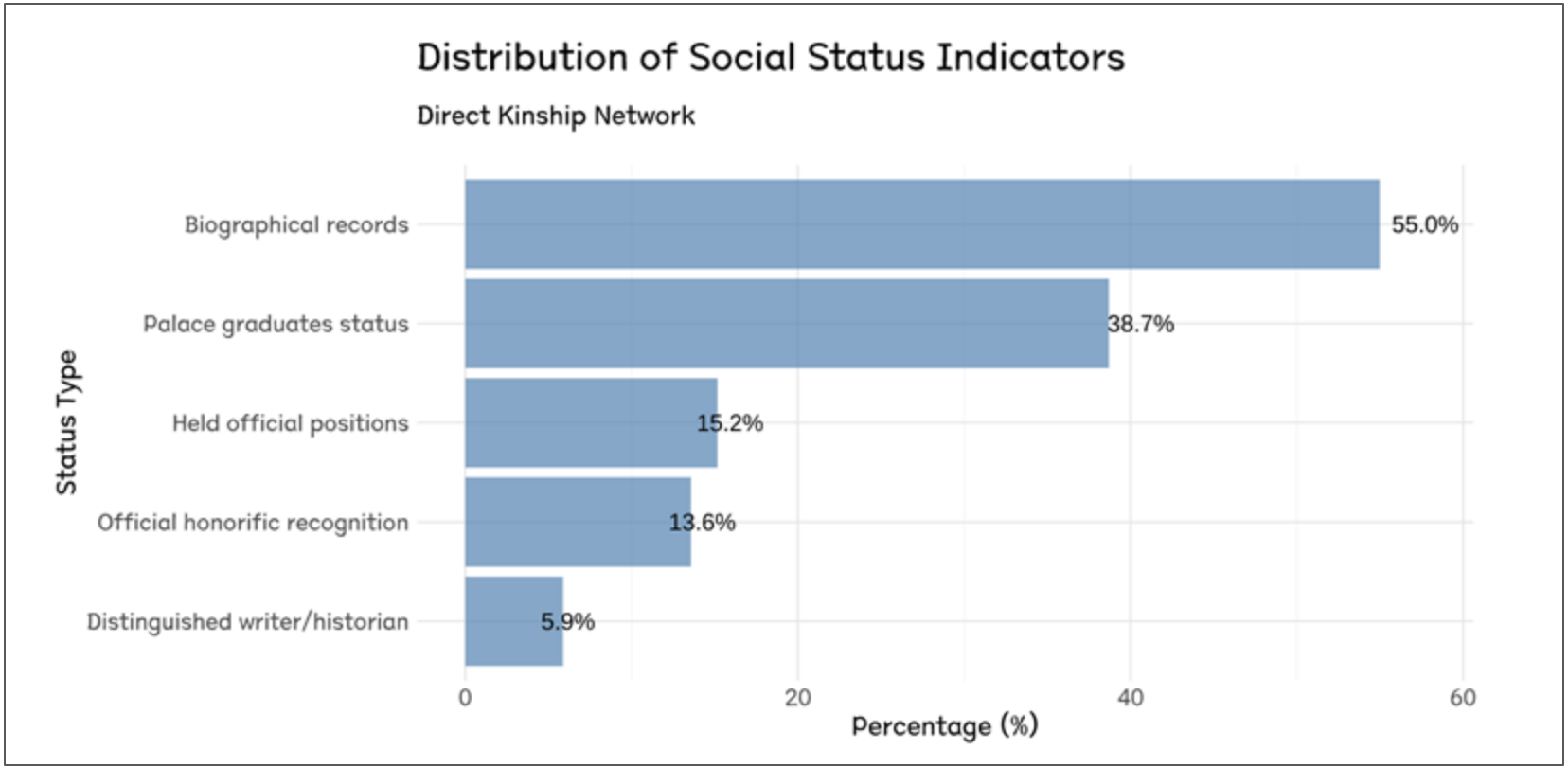


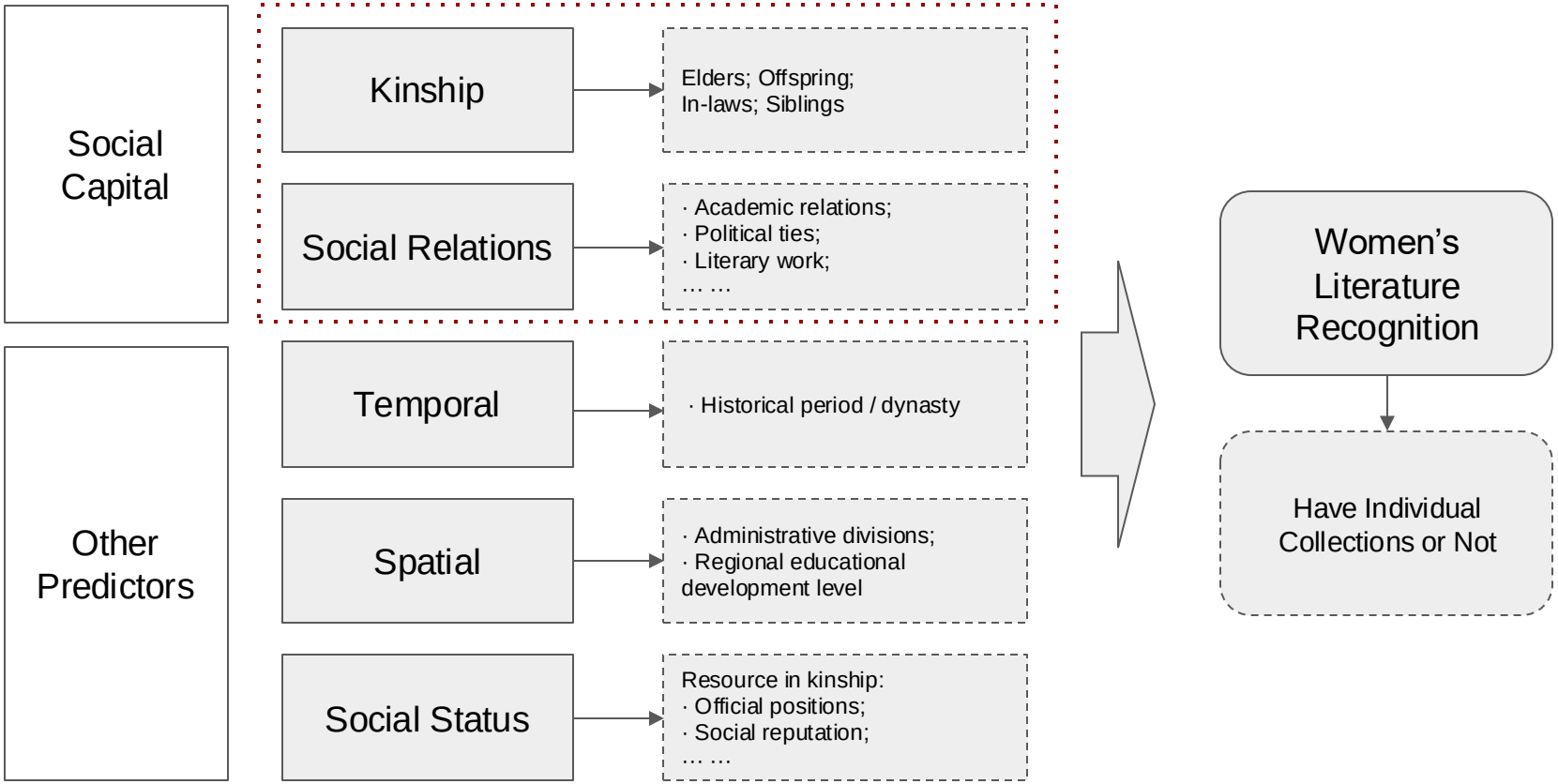
Table 2.4: Top 20 Women Poets by Number of Nearby Palace Graduates with 50km and 50-year window

Poet Name	Chinese Name	Birthplace	Birthplace (Chinese)	Birth Year	Palace Graduates (N)
Qin Liangyu	秦良玉	Zhong Zhou	忠州	1574	1461
Liang Mengzhao	梁孟昭	Qiantang	錢塘	1560	222
Lu Hui	陸慧	Haining Zhou	海寧州	1804	195
Gu Ci	顧慈	Jinkui	金匱	1754	163
Gu Ling	顧翎	Wuxi	無錫	1778	162
Ding Shanyi	丁善儀	Wuxi	無錫	1799	154
Fang Fangpei	方芳佩	Qiantang	錢塘	1728	147
Xu Yingyu	徐映玉	Qiantang	錢塘	1728	147
Xiang Heng	項蘅	Qiantang	錢塘	1743	146
Yuan Ji	袁機	Qiantang	錢塘	1720	142
Yang Sushu	楊素書	Qiantang	錢塘	1741	141

Social Status



Analysis Structure

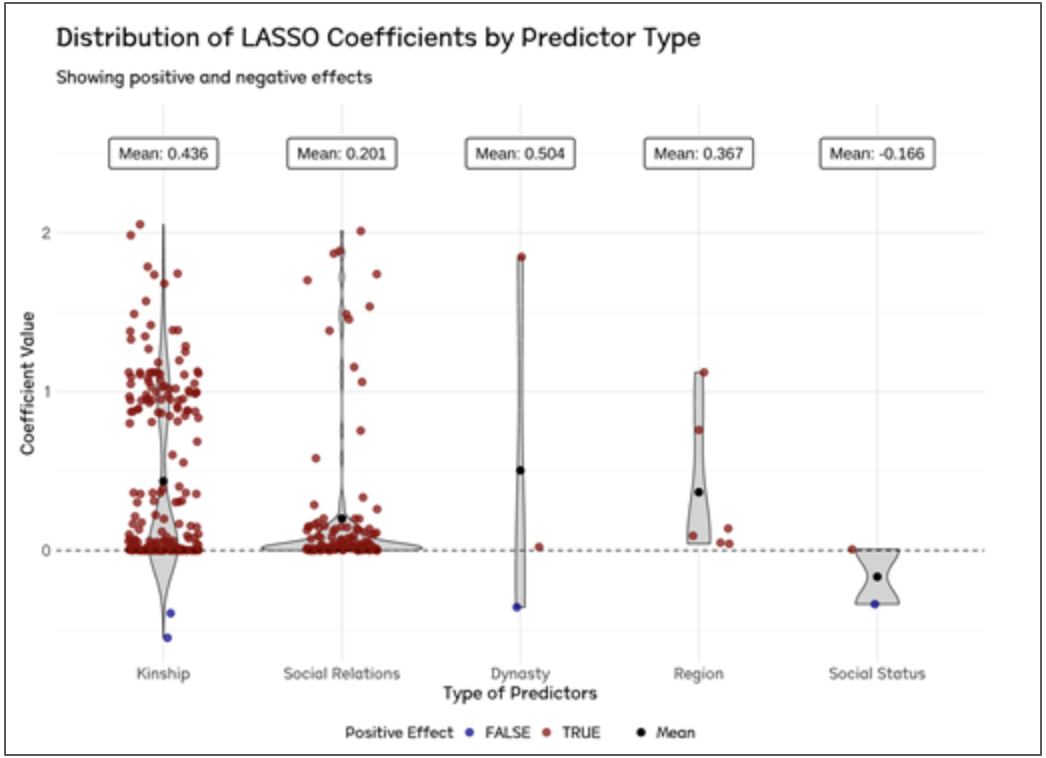


Lasso Regression: Individual Effects Within Networks

Many individuals in kinship and social relations have a positive impact.

The mean coefficient for kinship is significantly larger than that of social relations.

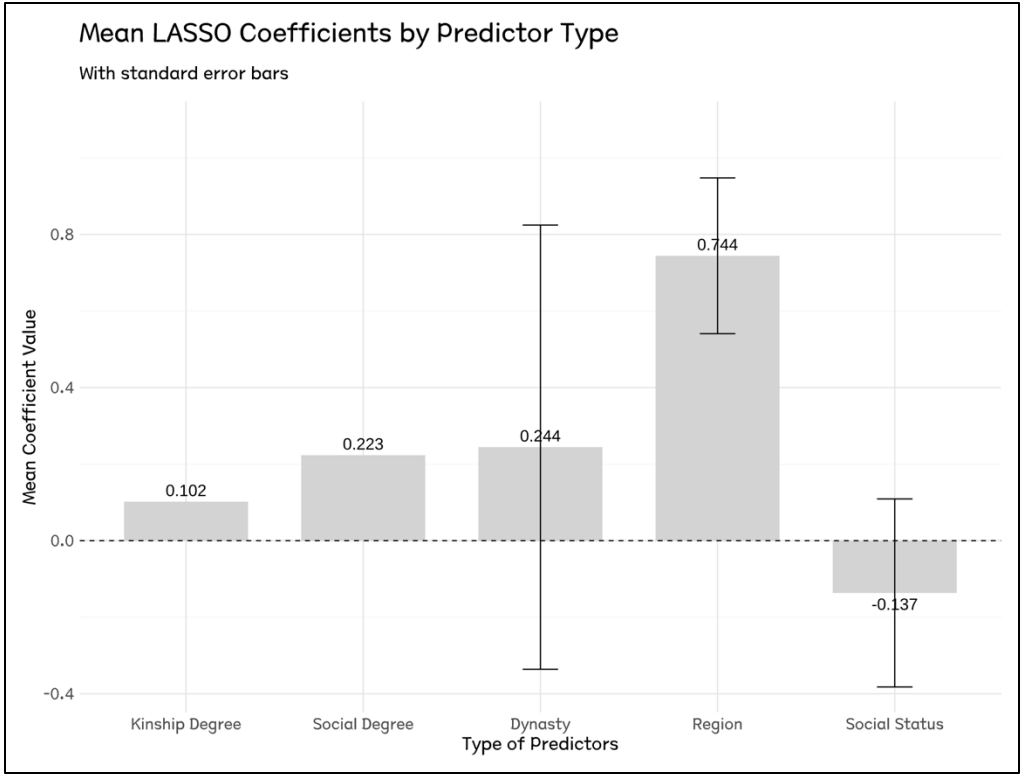
The coefficients for the spatial and temporal variables are greater than those for social relations.



Lasso Regression: Centrality Effects in Networks

Social Degree (0.223):

When considered as an aggregated indicator rather than simply calculating the mean of individual networks, the coefficient for social degree is higher than that of kinship.



Lasso Regression: Centrality Effects in Networks

The social degree effect is statistically significant with an estimated coefficient of 0.287 (95% CI: [0.086, 0.489]),

while the kinship degree effect remains statistically insignificant with an estimate of 0.092 (95% CI: [-0.096, 0.280]).

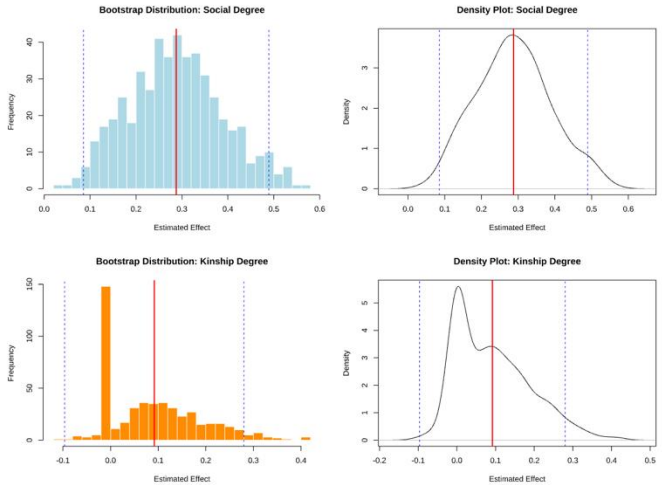


Figure 3.3: Bootstrap Distributions of Treatment Effects for Network Centrality Measures

Table 3.2: Double LASSO Treatment Effects (Bootstrap)

Network Type	Estimate	Std. Error	95% CI
Social Degree	0.287	0.103	[0.086, 0.489]
Kinship Degree	0.092	0.096	[-0.096, 0.280]

Note:
Based on 500 bootstrap replications
[1] Parallel processing using all available cores
[2] Bootstrap samples with replacement

Discussion

Conclusion

- The social relation network has a significantly positive effect on women's literary recognition, whereas the kinship network does not, underscoring the greater importance of social connections (non-kinship) for female literary figures compared to familial ties.

Future Work

- Limited data resources
- Difficulty in controlling the quality of these women poets' works

Thank you